

The Missing Scout

A Shadowdale Adventure for 5 Characters of 5th Level

Tier	2 (Levels 3–10)
Party	5 PCs · Level 5
Duration	~2 hours
Setting	Shadowdale, the Dalelands (Forgotten Realms)
Session Type	Introductory · 1 combat · 1 skill challenge



The Old Skull Inn — where the hook is offered.

Summary

A Shadowdale militia scout has gone missing on patrol along Old Skull's flank. The captain calls it desertion. The innkeeper doesn't buy it. Lady Ulphor quietly hires the party to find the truth — and what they find is the first confirmed Vhaeraunian drow staging camp above ground in twenty years. The adventure serves as a hard-edged introduction to Shadowdale, three of its key NPCs, the slow-boil drow threat beneath Old Skull, and — at the tail end — the Harpers.

Background — What's Actually Happening

Rellan Tassar, a twenty-six-year-old militia scout, was patrolling Old Skull's northern flank four days ago when he stumbled across a drow scouting party that had come up through a previously unknown cleft in the volcanic rock. The drow — three males sworn to Vhaeraun, led by an elite warrior named **Zeldraaz T'orrl** — subdued rather than killed him. They need intelligence on the dale's defenses before the larger Vhaeraunian effort commits, and a live militia scout is worth more than a dead one. Tassar has held out under interrogation for three days. He will not hold out for a fourth.

Corwick Helm, the militia captain, privately knows something is wrong — Tassar's patrol partner found signs of a struggle and reported them. But Corwick has chosen to file it as desertion pending "further review," because he is afraid that if he reports drow activity without proof, Lady Ulphor will order the dale to mobilize, and he is not ready to be the man who rang that particular bell. His hesitation is the adventure's ticking clock.

Scene 1 — The Hook at the Old Skull Inn

The Old Skull Inn is low-ceilinged, smoke-stained, and warm in a way that makes you realize how cold the ride into Shadowdale was. A one-eyed man behind the bar nods at you without a word and pours four — no, five — mugs of dark beer before you've stated an order. The fire crackles. A farmer at the next table is arguing quietly with his wife about a fence. Somewhere upstairs, someone laughs. For a village on the edge of the Underdark, Shadowdale feels aggressively ordinary.

Torval Dunmore runs the bar. He will not volunteer the hook immediately. Let the party order food, settle in, roleplay a little. After ten or fifteen minutes — when they've made themselves recognizable as capable people — he will wine down the bar in front of them and say quietly, without looking up:

"You lot look like you know what a sword is for. I've got something you might care about, if you've got patience for an old man's worry."



Torval Dunmore — proprietor of the Old Skull Inn.

Key Points Torval Shares

- Tessar is a good lad. Drinks here every seventh-day. Sends most of his pay to his widowed mother in Battledale.
- He was on a three-day patrol on Old Skull's northern flank. Back yesterday. Isn't back.
- Captain Helm is calling it desertion. Torval does not believe this, and says so plainly.
- Torval will not go to Lady Ulphor himself — "I'm a bar, not a messenger" — but he'll give the party a scrap of paper with her seal and a note in his handwriting: *Worth hearing.* — T.

If the party refuses: Torval shrugs and serves them another round. No pressure. Corwick himself approaches them in the morning, having reconsidered, and asks them directly — same hook, different delivery.

Scene 2 — Audience at the Ashaba House

The Ashaba House is built into the southern base of Old Skull, its rear wall raw granite. It is modest — two stories, no guards at the door, the great hall warmed by a single long hearth. A woman in working clothes stands at a map table when you enter. Brown skin, silver-streaked black hair in a tight braid, a deep blue teardrop stone on a silver chain at her throat. She looks up, reads Torval's note in three seconds, and says: "Close the door."



Lady Addee Ulphor, ruler of Shadowdale — bearer of the Pendant of Ashaba.

Lady Addee Ulphor is direct and unhurried. She asks the party three questions in sequence, regardless of their answers:

1. Who are you, where are you from, and who pays you?
2. Why should she trust you with something her own captain is mishandling?
3. What will you need?

The Offer

She offers **150 gp now and 150 gp on return** with Tessar (alive or confirmed dead), plus her personal goodwill — which in a dale means doors open that otherwise wouldn't. She provides:

- Tessar's patrol route (a rough sketch — useful for the skill challenge).
- A brass sigil of Shadowdale's militia, for bona fides if they encounter other patrols.
- A quiet warning: *"Do not tell Captain Helm what you find. Tell me first."*

She will not say the word "drow" aloud, but if pressed directly she will hold the party's eyes for a long moment and say: *"I will not tell you what I fear. I will tell you that if you find it, I will not be surprised."*

Scene 3 — Skill Challenge: Tracking Through the Living Wood

The party tracks Tessar's path through fey-touched woods along Old Skull's northern slope. The wood is quiet in a way that is actively wrong — animals have fled something, and the fey are watching the party from a careful distance.



Regional map — from Shadowdale through the Living Wood to Old Skull's northern flank.

Mechanics

Group skill challenge. The party needs **4 successes before 3 failures** to reach the drow camp undetected and with advantage on the opening round of combat. Failure still leads to the camp, but the drow are alerted — they lose surprise, Zeldrazz moves Tessar into a defensive position, and the terrain favors the ambushers.

Valid Approaches and DCs

Approach	DC	What it finds
Survival (tracking boots)	14	Tessar's boot prints; scuff where he was struck from behind
Nature (fey sign)	15	Fey have evacuated a corridor — the source is north-northwest
Perception (disturbed ground)	14	A black-fletched crossbow bolt, snapped. Drow work.
Investigation (patrol path)	15	Taken alive — blood trail too light for a killing wound
Persuasion/Insight (with a pixie)	13	"Pale-hair folk climb up from a crack in the rock"
Stealth (careful advance)	13	Counts toward undetected approach if committed to

Each PC may contribute **once per round** of the challenge. Repeating the same approach is allowed but each repeat raises the DC by 2. Clever out-of-list suggestions — a ranger's animal companion scouting, a druid speaking with a crow, a cleric using *speak with animals* — should be adjudicated as successes on a good roll.

Outcome

Success (4 successes first): The party finds the cleft in Old Skull's flank, approaches undetected, and gains **surprise** on the drow in Scene 4.

Failure (3 failures first): The party still finds the cleft, but the drow are alerted. No surprise. Zeldrizz positions Tessar as a hostage. Initiative is rolled at disadvantage for the party.

Scene 4 — Combat: The Drow Cleft



The cleft in Old Skull's northern flank at dusk. A broken bolt marks the approach.

A narrow fissure in Old Skull's granite flank, roughly thirty feet wide and sloping down into darkness. The drow have made camp in a widening chamber about forty feet inside — firelight would be deadly to their eyes, so they work by the dim glow of **faerzress** from the cavern walls and the moonlight filtering through the cleft above. Bedrolls, a banked smokeless fire, weapons, and **Rellan Tessar**, bound to a stalagmite at the rear of the chamber, conscious but unfocused.



Battle map — the drow cleft chamber. 5 ft per square.

Map Features

- **Entry cleft:** Difficult terrain; loose scree.
- **Main chamber:** ~30 ft × 40 ft. Stalagmites provide three-quarters cover at three points.
- **Rear alcove:** Where Tessar is bound. A PC can drag him behind a stalagmite with a bonus action after cutting the rope (DC 12 Strength or a blade).
- **Ceiling web:** A giant spider is anchored to the ceiling near the chamber's center. It drops into initiative on round 1.

Opposition

- **Zeldrazz T'orrl**, Drow Elite Warrior — CR 5 (×1)
- **Drow Scouts** — standard Drow, CR 1/4 (×2)
- **Giant Spider** — CR 1 (×1)

Adjusted XP: ~4,200 XP — Hard encounter for 5 × level 5.



Zeldrazz T'orrl — sworn to Vhaeraun. Note the iron half-mask amulet at his throat.

Read-Aloud on Reveal

The cleft opens into a low chamber lit by a sickly blue glow that seems to come from the rock itself. Three figures crouch near a banked fire — slender, white-haired, skin like polished obsidian. A fourth, taller and in black-chased mail, stands over a bound militiaman who lifts his head at the sound of your approach. The tall drow's hand is already on his sword. Above, something moves in the webbing on the ceiling.

Tactics

Round 1: If the party has surprise, Zeldrazz shouts in Undercommon and the drow scouts scatter for cover. The spider drops from the ceiling and attacks the closest front-line PC. If the party does *not* have surprise, Zeldrazz puts his blade to Tessar's throat and shouts in Common: *"Drop steel or he dies."* (He will not actually kill Tessar — Tessar is still worth more alive — but he will bluff convincingly.)

Round 2+: Scouts use hand crossbows from cover, aiming to knock a PC unconscious with poison (they want at least one more live prisoner). Zeldrazz engages the heaviest-armored or most dangerous PC in melee, using his two scimitar attacks and Parry reaction. The spider focuses on squishy targets.

At half HP, Zeldrazz tries to retreat down the cleft into the Underdark proper with Tessar over his shoulder. He will not fight to the death; his orders are to bring intelligence home.

Scaling

Easy: Remove one Drow Scout. Spider is CR 1/2 (giant wolf spider).

Medium: Remove the spider.

Hard (default): As written.

Deadly: Add a second Drow Elite Warrior, or give Zeldrazz a Drow Mage (CR 7) backing him up.

Treasure in the Chamber

- **Tessar himself** — 150 gp on delivery from Lady Ulphor.
- **Zeldrazz's scimitar** — drow-made, ornate, not magical but worth 75 gp to the right buyer.
- **A rolled vellum map fragment** in Zeldrazz's belt pouch — Undercommon script. Requires *comprehend languages* or a translator. Depicts Old Skull's northern flank with **three** marked sites, not just this one. (*Major future hook.*)
- **Zeldrazz's mask pendant** — a small iron half-mask, Vhaeraun's sigil. Worthless as treasure; priceless as intelligence. Confirms the incursion's patron god.
- **50 gp** in mixed coin across the camp (drow-struck and Dales-minted — the latter implying prior theft).

Scene 5 — Resolution and the Harper

The party returns to Shadowdale with Tessar. Lady Ulphor receives them in private. She pays the balance, accepts the map fragment and the mask pendant with the stillness of a woman whose worst guess has just been confirmed, and says:

"You have done Shadowdale a service it cannot yet acknowledge. I will ask you to keep this quiet. Captain Helm will be managed. If you find yourselves in the dale again — and I suspect you will — my door is not closed to you."

She does not mention the Harpers. She does not have to.



Rellan Tessar — rescued, bruised, and alive.

That evening at the Old Skull Inn, a thin man with ink-stained fingers sits down at the party's table without asking. **Orvyn Tal** introduces himself as a bookseller and slides a hand-drawn map of the Dalelands across the table as a gift. Then, mildly, without changing his tone:

"I understand you went for a walk on Old Skull today. I wonder if you happened to see anything that might interest a person who keeps an eye on such things."



Orvyn Tal — a bookseller who is not only a bookseller.

He does not name the Harpers. He is testing. If the party is forthcoming, he is grateful and hints that he and those he works with may have use for them. If the party is guarded, he is equally pleased — guarded is safer. Either way, the faction is now on the board. End session.

Appendix A — NPCs & Stat Blocks

Zeldrazz T'orrl — Drow Elite Warrior

Use: Drow Elite Warrior (MM p. 128). **CR** 5 · **AC** 18 · **HP** 71 · **Speed** 30 ft.
STR 14 (+2) · **DEX** 18 (+4) · **CON** 14 (+2) · **INT** 11 (0) · **WIS** 13 (+1) · **CHA** 12 (+1)
Saves Dex +7, Con +5, Wis +4 · **Skills** Perception +4, Stealth +10
Senses Darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 14 · **Languages** Elvish, Undercommon

Fey Ancestry. Advantage on saves against being charmed; magic can't put them to sleep.
Innate Spellcasting. Charisma; at will: *dancing lights*; 1/day each: *darkness*, *faerie fire*, *levitate* (self only).
Sunlight Sensitivity. Disadvantage on attacks and Perception (sight) in direct sun.

Actions — Multiattack: Two scimitar attacks.
Scimitar. +7 to hit, 1d6+4 slashing + 3d6 poison (once/turn on hit).
Hand Crossbow. +7 to hit, 30/120 ft., 1d6+4 piercing, plus DC 13 Con save: 1d4 hr unconscious if fail by 5+, else poisoned 1 hr.

Reaction — Parry. +3 AC against one melee attack that would hit (must see attacker, must be wielding melee weapon).

Drow Scout (×2)

Use: Drow (MM p. 128). **CR** 1/4 · **AC** 15 · **HP** 13 · **Speed** 30 ft.
STR 10 · **DEX** 14 (+2) · **CON** 10 · **INT** 11 · **WIS** 11 · **CHA** 12 (+1)
Senses Darkvision 120 ft. · **Languages** Elvish, Undercommon

Fey Ancestry · Innate Spellcasting (*dancing lights*, *darkness*, *faerie fire*).
Sunlight Sensitivity. Disadvantage on attacks and Perception (sight) in sun.

Shortsword. +4 to hit, 1d6+2 piercing.
Hand Crossbow. +4 to hit, 30/120 ft., 1d4+2 piercing, plus DC 13 Con save: 1 hr unconscious if fail by 5+, else poisoned 1 hr.

Giant Spider (×1)

Use: Giant Spider (MM p. 328). **CR** 1 · **AC** 14 · **HP** 26 · **Speed** 30 ft., climb 30 ft.
STR 14 (+2) · **DEX** 16 (+3) · **CON** 12 (+1) · **INT** 2 · **WIS** 11 · **CHA** 4
Senses Blindsight 10 ft., darkvision 60 ft.

Spider Climb · Web Walker · Web Sense.

Bite. +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., 1d8+3 piercing plus DC 11 Con: 2d8 poison (half on save); 0 HP from poison = stable but poisoned, paralyzed 1 hr.

Web (recharge 5–6). Ranged 30/60 ft., one Large or smaller creature, DC 12 Dex save or restrained; escape with DC 12 Str check or by destroying web (AC 10, HP 5, vulnerable to fire).

Rellan Tessar — Rescued Scout

Use: Commoner (MM p. 345). **CR** 0.
Human male, 26, light build. After rescue: dehydrated, bruised, three cracked ribs (exhaustion level 2 until a long rest). Grateful, not dramatic. Will return to militia service as soon as he's fit. (DM ADDITION — add to roster.md if he recurs.)

Canonical NPCs in Play

Torval Dunmore, **Lady Addee Ulphor**, **Orvyn Tal** — see *roster.md*. **Corwick Helm** — referenced but not onscreen this session.

Appendix B — Rewards

- **Gold:** 300 gp from Lady Ulphor + ~125 gp in camp goods = **~425 gp party total**.
- **XP (milestone suggested):** Advance to halfway through level 5, or award ~1,500 XP per PC if tracking discretely.
- **Reputation:** Lady Ulphor's private favor. Torval's trust. Orvyn Tal's cautious interest.
- **Ongoing hooks:** The drow map fragment (two more staging sites). Corwick Helm's hesitation (why didn't he report?). The Harpers' quiet interest.

Appendix C — Future Hook Seeds

1. **The other two cleft sites** from the map. Lady Ulphor will want them scouted before the Vhaeraunians reinforce.
2. **Corwick Helm** — Lady Ulphor will "manage" him, but *how* is an open question. A scene where she confronts him, or sends the party to confirm a suspicion, has teeth.
3. **Orvyn Tal's offer** — the Harpers have a standing question about whether the Vhaeraunian incursion is coordinated with anyone on the surface. They will pay for answers.
4. **Rellan Tessar** — if he lives, he becomes a low-level recurring NPC who owes the party his life and will volunteer for anything they need from the militia.

Canon Impact — Proposed Bible Updates

New material this session introduces that would want entries if canonized:

- **Rellan Tessar** (NPC) → *roster.md*
- **Zeldrazz T'orrl** (named drow villain) → roster entry only if he escapes
- **The northern cleft / drow staging camp** (location) → *geography.md*
- **The Vhaeraunian map fragment** (plot item / campaign macguffin) → *session-log.md* loose ends tracker

Appendix D — Player Handouts

The pages that follow reproduce every illustration in this adventure at handout size, one per page. Show them to your players at the table as each scene, character, or location comes into play. Each handout is labeled for the DM's reference; the players need only see the image.

The Old Skull Inn

Common Room — Shadowdale



Old Skull, Northern Flank

The Drow Cleft at Dusk



Lady Addee Ulphor

Lady of Shadowdale



Torval Dunmore

Innkeeper, the Old Skull Inn



Orvyn Tal

Bookseller (Harper Agent)



Zeldrazz T'orrl

Drow Elite Warrior of Vhaeraun



Rellan Tessar

Shadowdale Militia Scout



Regional Map

Shadowdale & the Living Wood



Battle Map — The Drow Cleft

5 ft per square

